

Tracing the Origins of the 'Parrot's Advice' Story in Arabic and Persian Literary Sources

سعيًا وراء أصول قصة 'نصيحة الببغاء'
في المصادر الأدبية العربية والفارسية

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Abstract

Allegory, as a form of didactic literature, not only teaches moral lessons and conveys sermons, but also reflects the literary heritage, culture, and civilization of past generations. One type of allegory is the fable, which consists of short stories in prose or verse featuring animal characters. The allegory of the "Talking Parrot," which has similar versions in both Persian and Arabic literature, is considered a fable. This present article provides a summary of the story and introduces its sources, then compares its similarities and differences in Arabic and Persian literature. By analyzing narrative elements such as theme, characters, plot, and dialogue, the study identifies the oldest sources in both languages. One of the key findings of this research which is based on comparative study is the emphasis across all sources on a shared moral lesson: avoiding greed and not regretting what is lost.

However, the structure of the story differs in Arabic and Persian sources. Additionally, the oldest known source of this story in Arabic literature is the book "Al-'Iqd al-Farid" written in the 10th century.

Keywords: Allegory, Didactic Literature, Fable, Talking Parrot.

الملخص:

يُعدّ التمثيل أحد أنواع الأدب التعليمي الذي لا يقتصر على تقديم الدروس الأخلاقية ونقل المواعظ، بل يُعدّ مرآة عاكسة لآثار الأدب القديم وثقافة وحضارة الأمم السابقة. ومن أنواع هذا التمثيل ما يُعرف بـ الفابل أو الحكاية التمثيلية، وهي قصص قصيرة نثرية أو شعرية تؤدي شخصياتها الحيوانية أدواراً رمزية. وتُعتبر قصة «الببغاء الناطق»، التي توجد لها نماذج متشابهة في الأدبين الفارسي والعربي، نموذجاً لهذا النوع من الفابل.

يقدم هذا البحث ملخصاً للقصة مع الإشارة إلى أهمّ مصادرها، ثم يتناول دراسة أوجه التشابه والاختلاف بين نسخها في الأدبين العربي والفارسي. ومن خلال تحليل العناصر السردية مثل الموضوع، والشخصيات، والحبكة، والحوار، يتوصّل البحث إلى تحديد أقدم مصدر لهذه الرواية في كلّ من اللغتين الفارسية والعربية.

ومن أبرز نتائج هذه الدراسة المقارنة أنّ جميع المصادر تؤكّد على درسٍ أخلاقي مشترك يتمثل في الابتعاد عن الطمع وعدم التحسّر على ما فات، مع اختلافٍ في بناء القصة بين المصادر العربية والفارسية. كما أنّ أقدم مصدرٍ معروف لهذه الحكاية في الأدب العربي هو كتاب «العقد الفريد» الذي أُلّف في القرن الرابع الهجري (القرن العاشر الميلادي).

الكلمات المفتاحية: التمثيل، الأدب التعليمي، الفابل، الببغاء الناطق.

1. Introduction

Since ancient times, imparting moral teachings has always been the mission and purpose of the prophets and with the advent of literature, many writers blended literary expression with educational themes, paving the way for the emergence of didactic literature. Didactic literature, as a literary genre, addresses social, ethical, and mystical issues, offering advice and moral guidance. “Thus, didactic literature refers to works that perceive human prosperity in the improvement of ethical character and focus on nurturing spiritual capacities and teaching moral values” (Moshraf, 2009: 9). This type of literature often manifests in the form of stories aimed at educating and admonishing the audience. From ancient times, poets and writers employed this literary approach to reinforce or elaborate on the central ideas of their works. One form of didactic literature that conveys a thought or message through tales or stories is allegory. Many literary masterpieces have an allegorical aspect; for example, Masnavi Ma’navi is filled with educational stories and narratives. Ferdowsi’s Shahnameh, Attar’s Conference of the Birds, and Saadi’s Golestan and Bustan, along with many other poetic collections, are regarded as examples of didactic and allegorical works.

A subcategory of allegory found in these works is the fable. Fables which are short tales featuring animal characters, convey moral themes through prose and verse. “It could be said that in the world of literature, animal-based storytelling is one of the most widely used

and popular forms of narrative. The simplicity, brevity, the universality of the message in the stories, and the familiarity of the characters and their behaviors for the audience are among the factors that contribute to the widespread appeal of these types of stories” (Nazemian; 1978: 33).

First and foremost, it is necessary to highlight the shared presence of such stories in both Arabic and Persian literatures. Through examining the origins of this allegorical tale in Persian and Arabic literatures, as well as their mutual influences, the term “comparative literature” arises.

Comparative literature, which examines the literary relationships among nations, is defined as “the study of the connections and interactions between the literatures of different nations and peoples around the world. A researcher akin to someone stationed at the linguistic borders of a nation, observing and monitoring all the intellectual and literary exchanges occurring across those borders between that nation and other distant and nearby people. Therefore, it can perhaps be said that in comparative literature, what the researcher and critic focus on is not the literary work itself, but rather the study of how a literary work of one nation manifests and reflects in the literature of another. In other words, what draws the attention of scholars in comparative literature is the adaptation and modifications that each nation applies to the literary works it adopts and borrows from another.” (Zarrinkoub; 1982: 125-126).

Among these shared moral stories is the allegory of “the talking parrot.” Through the conducted studies, numerous examples of this story have been identified in both Persian and Arabic literature. In addition to being cited in ancient sources, poets have also composed it in verse, demonstrating the significance and universality of this moral allegory.

Among the Arabic sources of this story, in chronological order, are:

“Al-Iqd al-Farid” by Ibn Abd Rabih (246-328 AH), “Kamal al-Din wa Tamam al-Ni’mah” by Sheikh Saduq Ibn Babawayh al-Qummi (306-381 AH), “Hilyat al-Awliya wa Tabaqat al-Asfiya” by Abu Nu’aym Al-Isfahani (430 AH), “Ihya’ Ulum al-Din” by Abu Hamid Muhammad Ghazali (450-505 AH), and “Al-Adhkiya” by Ibn al-Jawzi (597 AH).

The Persian sources include “Javame al-Hikayat” by Aafi (6th-7th century), “Kimiaye- Sa’adat” by Ghazali Tousi (450-505 AH), “(The Parrot book), Javaher al-Asmar” by Emad ibn Muhammad Al-Thaghri (8th century), and “Jame’ al-Tamthil” by Habla Roudi (11th century AH).

Attar and Rumi have versified this allegorical tale in Persian literature. The present study, employing a comparative-analytical method, seeks to address the following questions while introducing the Arabic and Persian sources of this narrative and comparing their differences and similarities. It will then examine the

structural elements of the story, including themes, plot, characters, dialogue, and point of view.

1. What is the oldest source of the story?
2. What is the major distinction and difference between Arabic and Persian prose sources? Content or form?
3. Which of the two Persian poets' storytelling styles is closer to the original source?

2. Background of the Research:

Many books have been written on didactic literature. For example, "Essays InIranian Educational Literature" by Maryam Mosharaf (2009) examines the didactic literature of the fourth and fifth centuries and explores the educational movements associated with it. There are journals dedicated to this field, publishing numerous articles in each period. One such article is "the study of the origin of didactic poetic literature and its course of development in Iran" by Ahmadreza Yalmehha (2016), published in the Research of Didactic Literature Review. (Issue 29, pp. 61-90). This study addresses the question of whether the content and themes of didactic literature in Iran from pre-Islamic times to the present are connected to contemporary social discourses.

Additionally, many studies have been conducted on allegorical storytelling, particularly in the well-known genre of fables. For instance "Allegory, Nature, Types, Function" by Mahmoud Fattouhi (2004), published in the

Journal of the Faculty of Literature and Humanities (Issues 47-49, pp. 141-177), categorizing different functions of allegory and explains their functions and domains.

Another relevant study is “Allegorical Fables (Animals)” by Mohammad Jafari Qanavati (2009), published in the Quarterly Journal of Iranian People's Culture (Issue 17, pp. 145-161). The author clarifies the distinction between animal allegories and other folktales by highlighting their specific functions and roles.

Additionally, there are numerous books and studies on this subject, but it is not possible to mention all of them here. However, regarding the present research topic, numerous articles and books have examined the origins of allegorical stories. One notable example is “Hadiths and Stories in Rumi's Masnavi” by Badi’ al-Zaman Furuzanfar (2002). In this book, the author introduces various hadiths and narratives, along with the original texts that Rumi drew from in his works. Similarly, another notable work is “Sources of the Stories and Allegories in Attar Nishabouri's Masnavis” by Fatemeh Sanati Nia, which belongs to the same category of literature.

Among the articles that have addressed the origins of stories in Arabic and Persian literature is the article “Al-Tabar al- Masbuk in the Advice of the King Ghazali: the sources of several tales from One Thousand and One Nights” by Ahmad Rahim Khani Samani, Mohammad Hakim Azar, and Mazaher Nikkhah (2018), published in

Comparative Literature studies (Issue 29, pp. 57-82). This research compares the Arabic text of "One Thousand and One Nights" with the Arabic translation of "Al-Muluk's advice" and argues that "Al-Tabar al-Masbuk" is the source of five stories from "One Thousand and One Nights". However, no research has yet been conducted on the sourcing of the allegorical tale "The Talking Parrot" and the analysis of its narrative elements.

3. Summary of the story

A man caught a bird. The bird began to speak and asked him, "What will you do with me now?" The man smiled and replied, "I will slaughter and eat you." The bird became worried and said, "Eating me won't benefit you, and it won't satisfy your hunger. If you promise to let me go, I'll give you three pieces of advice that will lead to your prosperity. But you must let me give the first advice while I'm still in your hands, the second once you release me and I sit on a tree, and the third when I sit on a mountain." The man agreed and asked for the first piece of advice. The bird said, "Never regret what you've lost." The man then released the bird. The bird perched on a tree and gave the second piece of advice, "Never believe every lie you hear." Once the bird felt safe, it told the man, "You made a big mistake by letting me go because I have a precious pearl inside my stomach that weighs twenty mithqals. Upon hearing this, the man sighed deeply, expressing regret and sorrow. He then asked the bird for the third piece of advice. As the bird

flew toward the mountain, it said, "How can I give you the third advice when you've already ignored the first two? Didn't I tell you not to regret what you've lost? but now you are regretting. Didn't I tell you not to believe a lie? How could I possibly have such a large pearl inside me when my entire body doesn't even weigh that much?" With these words, the bird flew away.

4. Arabic sources:

4-1 . Al-Igd al-Farid (Ibn Abd Rabbah)

This book, written in the 4th century AH by the great Andalusian poet and scholar Shihab al-Din Abu Amr Ahmad ibn Muhammad ibn Abd Rabbih (born 246 AH - died 328 AH), holds significant importance in the history of Andalusia. It is a collection of history, narratives, and anecdotes compiled into nine sections and twenty-five chapters. The mentioned story appears in the third section and the seventh chapter of the book titled "Kitab al-Jawhara fi al-Amthal" under the section "Amthal Rawatha al-Ulama" in the part "Mathal fi al-Riya" with the title "Isra'ili wa Qubara".

«Dawud ibn Abi Hind on the authority of al-Sha'bi: A man from the Children of Israel hunted a bird, and it said: What do you want to do with me? He said: Shall I slaughter you and eat you? It said: By God, I cannot cure my illness nor can I satisfy my hunger, but I will teach you three things that are better for you than eating me: As for the first, I will teach it to you while I am in your

hand, the second when you are on this tree, and the third when you are on the mountain. He said: Give me the first. She said: Do not be anxious about what you have missed. So he let her go. When she was on the tree, he said: Give me the second. She said: Do not believe that what will not happen will happen. Then she flew and landed on the mountain and said: O wretched one! If you were to slaughter me, I would extract from my crop a pearl weighing twenty mithqals. He bit his lips and was anxious, then he said: Give me the third. She said to him: You have forgotten the two, so how can I teach you the third? Did I not tell you not to be anxious about what you have missed? You were anxious for me when I destroyed you, and I said to you: Do not believe that what will happen will happen! So you believed! I, with my bones and feathers, do not weigh twenty mithqals, so how can there be something in my crop that weighs that?» (ibn abd rabbah:1983:8)

4-2. Kamal al-Din and Tamam al-Nim'ah (Sheikh Sadouq)

The alternate title of this book is "Ikmal al-Din wa Itmam al-Ni'mah", was written by the Shia scholar Abu Ja'far Muhammad ibn Ali ibn al-Husayn ibn Babawayh al-Qummi, known as Sheikh Saduq (born in 306 AH - died in 381 AH). In this book, he addresses the topic of the occultation and reappearance of Imam Mahdi (may God hasten his reappearance). The first part of the book contains 32 chapters, while the second part extends from

chapter 32 to the end of chapter 58. The mentioned story is narrated in chapter 54 under the title "The Story of Bluher and Yudasov."

«The wise man said: A man had an orchard which he tended and took good care of. One day, he saw a bird perched on a tree in the orchard, eating some of its fruit. This angered him, so he set a trap and caught it. When he was about to kill it, Allah Almighty made it speak. He said to the owner of the orchard: You are anxious to kill me, but there is nothing that will satisfy your hunger or strengthen you. Is there anything better for you than what you are about to do? The man said: What is it? The bird said: Release me and I will teach you three words which, if you remember them, will be better for you than your family and wealth. He said: I have done so, so tell me about them. The bird said: Remember what I say to you: Do not grieve over what you have missed, do not believe in what will not be, and do not ask for what you cannot bear. When he finished the words, Allah let it go, and it flew away and landed on some trees. Then he said to the man: If you knew what you missed from me, you would know that you have missed something very great from me. From the matter, the man said: What is that? The bird said: If you had gone ahead with what you intended to do, which was to kill me, you would have extracted from my chick a pearl the size of a goose's egg, and that would have been enough for you for the rest of your days. When the man heard that from him, he felt remorse for what he had missed, and said: Leave what has passed,

and come, I will take you to my house, where I will treat you well and give you a good stay. The bird said to him: O ignorant one, I do not think that you protected me when you got hold of me, nor did you benefit from the words with which I ransomed myself from you. Did I not command you not to grieve over what you missed, nor to believe in what will not be, nor to seek what you cannot attain? Are you not grieving for what you have lost and asking me to return to you and asking for what you cannot attain and believing that in my chick is a pearl like a goose's egg, and that my whole being is smaller than its eggs? I had promised you not to believe in what does not exist and that your nation made their idols with their own hands and then claimed that they are the ones who created them and protected them from being stolen for fear of them and claimed that they are the ones who protect them and spent on them from their earnings and money and claimed that they are the ones who provide for them. So they asked for what is not attainable and believed in what is not, so what the owner of the garden was bound by it is bound by it.» (Sheikh Sadouq: 1412: 552)

4-3 . **Nathr al-Dur fi al-Muhadarat** (Abu Sa'd Abi)

«And they said: A man caught a finch. When it was in his hand, it said: What do you want to do with me? He said, 'I intend to slaughter you and eat you.' It said, 'I will not cure hunger, nor will I satisfy starvation. But if you leave me, I will teach you three words that are better

for you than eating me. The first, I will teach you while I am in your hand. The second, I will teach you while I am on the tree. And the third, when I reach the mountain.’ He said, ‘Tell me.’ So it said, ‘Do not grieve over what you have missed.’ He released it, and it went to the tree. Then it said, ‘Do not believe what cannot be.’ Then it said, ‘O wretched man, if you had slaughtered me, you would have extracted from my crop two pearls that are better for you than a treasure.’ He bit his lips in regret, then said, ‘Teach me the third.’ It said, She said: You have forgotten the two, so how can I teach you the third? Didn’t I tell you: Do not grieve over what you have missed, and do not believe what cannot be? My feathers and flesh do not weigh as much as two pearls, so how could that be in my crop?’ Then it flew away and was gone.» (Abi:2004: 146-147)

4-4 . Hilyat al-Awliya’ wa Tabaqat al-Asfiya (Abu Nu’aym al-Isfahani)

Ahmad ibn Abdullah, known as Abu Nu’aym al-Isfahani (336 AH – 430 AH), was a renowned hadith scholar of the 4th and 5th centuries and the author of this book. Hilyat al-Awliya’ is a ten-volume work that presents the biographies of the great companions of the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH), as well as the ascetics and mystics from the early Islamic period up to the time of the author. The mentioned story is narrated in the fourth volume of this work.

«My father told us, saying: Ibrahim ibn Muhammad ibn al-Hasan told us, saying: Muhammad ibn Abdullah al-Razi told us, saying: Maslama ibn 'Alqama told us, from Dawud, from al-Sha'bi: "A man caught a lark. When it was in his hand, it said: 'What do you want to do with me?' He said: 'I will slaughter you and eat you.' It said: 'I will neither satisfy your hunger nor cure your craving. But I will teach you three qualities that are better for you than eating me. One I will teach you while I am in your hand, the second on the mountain, and the third on the tree.' He said: 'Tell me the first one.' It said: 'Do not grieve over what you have lost!' When it was on the mountain, it said: 'Do not believe in what cannot be!' When it was on the tree, it said: 'O wretched one! If you had slaughtered me, you would have found two pearls in my crop, each weighing twenty mithqals.' He said: 'He bit his lips and grieved.' He said: 'Tell me the third one.' It said: 'I have forgotten two, so how can I tell you the third? Did I not tell you, do not grieve over what you have lost, and do not believe in what cannot be! Me, with my feathers, flesh, and blood, I would not weigh twenty mithqals!' He said: 'So it flew away and left» .(Al-Isfahani; 1996: 316)

4-5 . Ihya' Ulum al-Din (Al-Ghazali)

Commonly known as Ihya' al-Ulum, this book was written in Arabic by Abu Hamid Muhammad al-Ghazali (450–505 AH). It is a religious, ethical, and mystical work structured into four sections (rub'): the quarter of

worship ('ibadat), the quarter of social customs ('adat), the quarter of destructive vices (muhlikat), and the quarter of salvific virtues (munjiyat). The mentioned story appears in the quarter of destructive vices (muhlikat), within the section "The Book of Condemnation of Miserliness and Love of Wealth", specifically under the subsection "On the Condemnation of Greed and Covetousness, and the Praise of Contentment and Despairing of What Others Possess."

«Al-Sha'bi said: It was narrated that a man caught a bird and it said: What do you want to do with me? He said: Shall I slaughter you and eat you? It said: By God, I am not cured of my hunger nor satisfied with my pain, but I will teach you three things that are better for you than eating me. As for the first, I will teach you while I am in your hand. As for the second, when you are on the tree, and as for the third, when you are on the mountain, it said: Bring me the first. It said: Do not be anxious about what you have missed. So he left it. When it was on the tree, he said: Bring me the second. Do not believe in what will not happen. Then it flew and landed on the mountain. It said: O wretched one, if you slaughtered me, I would extract from my crop two pearls, each weighing twenty mithqals. He bit his lip and gasped and said: Bring me the third. It said: You have forgotten two, so how can I tell you the third? Didn't I tell you not to be anxious about what you have missed and not to believe in what will not happen? My flesh, blood, and feathers are not twenty mithqals. So how can there be two pearls

in my crop, each weighing twenty mithqals? Then it flew and was gone. This is an example of excess. The greed of man blinds him from attaining the truth until he deems that which cannot be will be.» (Al-Ghazali: 2005: 1144)

4-6 . Al-Adhkiya (Ibn Jawzi)

Abu al-Faraj Abdulrahman ibn Ali Abu al-Fada'il Jamal al-Din al-Baghdadi, known as Ibn Jozay (510 AH – 592 AH), authored the Arabic book *Al-Athkiya'* in thirty-three chapters. This work focuses on the topic of intelligence and wisdom. The mentioned story appears in the thirty-third chapter titled "On the Examples and Proverbs Given by the Arabs and Philosophers through the Speech of Dumb Animals, Which Indicate Intelligence."

«Al-Sha'bi said: I was told that a man caught a bird, and when it was in his hand it said: What do you want to do with me? He said: Shall I slaughter you and eat you? It said: I am neither cured of my illness nor satisfied of my hunger, but I will teach you three things that are better for you than eating me: Either I will teach you one while I am in your hand, or the second on the tree, or the third on the mountain. He said: Bring me the first one. It said: Do not be anxious about what you have missed. He said: When it was on the tree, he said to it: Bring me the second. It said to him: Do not believe in what cannot be. When it was on the mountain, it said to him: O wretched one, if you slaughter me, you would have extracted from my crop two pearls, in each one twenty mithqals. He

said: He bit his lips and gasped, then he said to it: Bring me the third. It said: You have forgotten two, so how can I tell you the third? Didn't I tell you: Do not be anxious about what you have missed, and do not believe in what cannot be, that I, my feathers and my flesh, will not be twenty mithqals. He said: And it flew away.» (Ibn jawzi:no date: 241-242)

5. Comparison of Arabic Sources:

1. The earliest prose source of this story dates back to the 4th century, found in *Al-Iqd al-Farid*, written by Ibn Abd Rabbah.

2. In Persian poetic literature, both Rumi and Attar, inspired by ancient sources, have created poetic renditions of the narrative. We will first examine the Arabic sources, then turn to the Persian sources, and finally highlight the similarities and differences between the two sources.

3. In terms of narrative structure, the stories found in "*Hilyat al-Awliya*", "*Ihya Ulum*", and "*Al-Adhkiya*" are quite similar to the ancient source "*Al-Iqd al-Farid*." Additionally, the source "*Kamal al-Din and Tamam al-Ni'mah*" independently covers this particular story, although the core theme remains consistent across all versions. Further details will be discussed below.

4. The story is narrated in all sources through the words of Sha'bi, and in *Kamal al-Din*, it is attributed to the sage with the phrase "*Qal al-Hakim*".

5. The characters in the story are portrayed as both human and animal. The human characters are described as "A man from the Children of Israel" or simply "a man." The animal character in *Al-Iqd al-Farid* is described as a *gabra* (a type of bird: Lark), while in *Hilyat al-Awliya'*, *Ihya' al-Ulum*, and *Al-Adhkiya'*, the animal is a *ganbarah* (a type of bird: Lark). In *Kamal al-Din*, the animal is referred to as an *Eusfour* (a sparrow).

6. After being captured, the bird engages in a conversation with the hunter and the story continues with a question-and-answer exchange: "The bird said: 'What do you intend to do with me?' The hunter replied: 'I will slaughter you and eat you!' The bird then said: 'By God, I am neither enough to satisfy hunger nor to cure craving, but I will teach you three pieces of wisdom that are better for you than eating me.'" (Ibn Abd Rabbih, 1983:8) . However, in "*Kamal al-Din wa Tamam al-Ni'mah*, the bird does not ask the hunter any questions. Instead, it first points out the futility of slaughtering it and then offers its advice:

"When the hunter was about to slaughter it, Allah Almighty made the bird speak by his power. It said to the owner of the orchard: "You are eager to slaughter me, but I am neither enough to satisfy your hunger nor to strengthen you from weakness. Would you like something better than what you intend to do?"

7. All Arabic sources mention two pieces of advice from the bird: "Do not grieve over what you have lost"

and "Do not believe what is impossible." However, "Kamal al-Din wa Tamam al-Ni'mah also mentions a third piece of advice: "Do not seek what you cannot attain."

8. The bird sets a condition for giving advice to the hunter, specifying three locations. In the sources "Al-Iqd al-Farid" "Ihya Ulum" and "Al-Adhkiya", these locations are "hand, tree, and mountain." While in the source "Haliyaal-Awlia "the order is "hand, mountain, tree." In contrast, in "Kamal al-Din," the bird delivers all three pieces of advice while still in the hunter's hand. It then flies to a tree after being set free.

9. In all sources, after giving the second piece of advice and reaching the third location (mountain or tree) where it feels safe, the bird speaks about a twenty-mithqal pearl. However, in Kamal al-Din wa Tamam al-Ni'mah, the bird first delivers all three pieces of advice, then, after being freed, mentions the pearl as a way to test the hunter.

10. The sources differ in how they describe the false pearl supposedly inside the bird: In Hilyat al-Awliya', Ihya' al-Ulum, and Al-Adhkiya', it is mentioned as "two pearls, each weighing twenty mithqals". Meanwhile, in Al-Iqd al-Farid, it is described as "a single pearl weighing twenty mithqals". In "Kamal al-Din wa Tamam al- Ni'mah" the pearl is described as "the size of a goose egg".

11. In all sources, the bird refutes the claim about the twenty-mithqal pearl by arguing that its own body does not weigh twenty mithqals. It questions how it could possibly carry such a heavy pearl inside itself and refers to both its internal and external body parts to emphasize the impossibility.

Al-Iqd al-Farid	Me, my bones, and my feathers
Kamal al-Din	All of them are smaller than their eggs (the goose)
Haliya al-Awlia	I am my feathers, my flesh and my blood
Ihya'a Ulum	I am my flesh, my blood, and my feathers
Al-Adhkiya	Me, my feathers and my flesh

6. Persian sources:

6-1 .**Buluhar va Budasf** (Sheikh Saduq)

«The Tale of the Greedy Man and the Sparrow. There was once a man who owned a garden. He worked hard to maintain and cultivate it with great care. One day, he saw a sparrow perched on one of his trees, eating its fruit. He became angry, set a trap and caught the sparrow. As he was about to kill it, God, in His infinite power, granted the sparrow the ability to speak. The sparrow said to the gardener, "You are intent on killing

me, but there is not enough meat on my body to satisfy your hunger or give you any strength. Instead, let me guide you to something far better than killing me. "The man asked, what is it ? the sparrow replied, "If you set me free, I will teach you three pieces of advice. If you remember them and act upon them, they will be more beneficial to you than your possessions. The man promised to do so, and the sparrow said: Do not grieve over what is lost. Do not believe the impossible. Do not seek what cannot be attained. Upon hearing this, the man released the sparrow. The bird immediately flew to a tree and called out, "had you known what you've missed by letting me go, you would realize you've lost something of immense value. "The man asked, "What is it? "The sparrow replied, "Had you killed me, you would have found inside me a pearl the size of a goose's egg. This pearl would have secured your independence for life and brought you immense wealth. " When the man heard this, he was filled with deep regret and sorrow. However, he tried not to show it. Instead, he said, "Let us not dwell on the past. Come, I'll take you home, cherish you, and provide you with a safe and comfortable place to stay. "The sparrow responded, "Fool ! I know that once you gain control of me, you will kill me. You haven't benefited at all from my words. Did I not tell you not to grieve over what is lost, not to believe the impossible, and not to seek what cannot be attained? And yet, you grieve over what is past and lost. You seek my return, knowing it's impossible. And you even believed that

inside my tiny body was a pearl the size of a goose's egg-when my entire body is not even that big!» (Sheikh Saduq: 1986: 84-85).

6-2 .Javami al-Hikayat va Lawame al-Revayat(Aufi)

The mentioned book is a collection of stories containing historical, moral, and religious lessons, enriched with Persian anecdotes. It is structured into four sections and one hundred chapters. The following narrative appears in the fourth section of the book.

«The Sparrow's Advice: it is told that a man had put a sparrow in a cage, and brought it to the market to sell. Another man came, bought the bird, and took it home. The sparrow then spoke to its new owner, saying, "What benefit do you gain from killing me? Let me teach you three words that will benefit you. However, I will share the first lesson while I am still in the cage, the second while sitting on your hand, and the third after I am free and perched on a tree." So he took him to the desert and asked, "What is your first lesson? "The sparrow replied, "Whatever you lose, never grieve over it, for it will never return to you. Hearing this, the man released the bird. The man took him out and said: What is the second? The sparrow said, "Never believe the impossible or accept absurd claims as truth." The man found this advice wise and let the bird go. The sparrow flew to the top of a tree and then called out, "Foolish man! You have made a great mistake by setting me free, for inside my stomach was a precious jewel weighing twenty mithqals (a

measure of gold). "Upon hearing this, the man fell down to the ground in despair, filled with deep regret. The sparrow said: You heard my words and forgot them right away. First, I told you not to grieve over what is lost, and here you are lamenting. Since I have passed away from you, if you cry a thousand times, I will not come back; Second, I told you not to believe the impossible. My entire body does not even weigh ten mithqals, so how could I possibly have had a jewel twice that weight inside me?" The man sighed and said, "At least tell me the third lesson so I may still benefit from it." The sparrow replied, "Because you treated me with kindness, I will now offer you something of true value. Beneath this tree, there is a buried golden pitcher. Dig it up and use it for your benefit." The man eagerly dug the ground and found the golden pitcher. Amazed, he asked, "How strange that you could see treasure hidden beneath the earth, yet you did not see the trap that had captured you!" He said: "You do not know that when the Creator will bring a decree to pass, He will blind the seeing through the will of the ignorant so that they cannot see the way out." With this newfound treasure, the man became wealthy and returned home, enriched both in fortune and wisdom.» (Aufi: 1984: 363 -364)

6-3 .**Kimiaye Sa'adat** (Ghazal Tousi)

This book was written in Persian by Abu Hamid Imam Muhammad al-Ghazali al-Tusi in the final years of the fifth century AH. It consists of two volumes: The

first volume includes the quarter of worship (Ruba'-i 'Ibadat) and the quarter of transactions (Ruba'-i Mu'amalat). The second volume covers the quarter on of Destructive Vices (Ruba'-i Muhlikat) and the quarter Saving Virtues (Ruba'-i Munjiyat). The mentioned story appears in the quarter on Destructive Vices, in the sixth principle, under the section "the Cure for stinginess and Greed in rounding up wealth" specifically under the title "Finding the Harm of greed and the benefits of contentment.

«Sha'bi (may God have mercy on him) tells the story of a man who caught a small bird. The bird said, "What do you want from me?" The man replied, "I will kill and eat you." The bird said, "Eating me will bring you no benefit. Instead, let me teach you three pieces of advice that are far more valuable than my flesh. The first, I will tell you while I am in your hand; the second, once you release me and I sit on a tree; and the third, after I have flown to the top of a mountain. "Upon hearing this, the man bit his fingers in regret and cried out, "Alas! What a loss! Tell me the third lesson now!" The bird said, "You have already forgotten the first two-why do you ask for the third? I told you not to grieve over what is lost, yet here you are mourning. I told you not to believe the impossible, yet you believed that my tiny body could contain two pearls weighing twenty mithgals each! How could that even be possible?" With that, the bird spread its wings and flew away. This story is told to illustrate

that when greed arises, it is easy to believe in all things impossible.» (Ghazal Tousi: 2001:162)

6-4. **Tuti-Nameh Javaher al-Asmar** (imad bin Muhammad Thughari)

«The parrot said: The narrators of ancient tales relate that a man in the market of Damascus bought a colorful and delicate sparrow for a dirham from a hunter. He tied a string to its foot and, holding it in his hand, took it home for his children. The sparrow, speaking in its own way, addressed the man: ‘There is no benefit for you in keeping me. If you release me, I will give you three words of advice, on the condition that I speak two points while held in your hand, and the third word while perched atop the tree of your house.’ The man agreed to these words and purchased the points of wisdom for a dirham. The sparrow said: ‘The first word is that when a blessing is lost, one should not grieve or be saddened by its absence, because, in truth, that blessing was never truly yours. The second is that if someone speaks of impossibilities and wonders, one should beware of believing them firmly and should avoid paying attention to such words.’ Having said this, the sparrow flew to the branch and said: ‘What foolishness was this, that you released me and gave ear to my words? You should not have let me go, but rather have kept me as though I were your very life. For, in my belly, there is a pearl weighing twenty mithqals ! See what folly and ignorance you have committed, that you have let me go and have wasted such

a pearl!’ The man immediately became filled with regret, wringing his hands. The sparrow said: ‘Did I not, just now, give you the advice that you should not lament what is lost and should not heed the impossible? For I am a weak bird. Where could a twenty-mithqal pearl be contained in my crop? You hold such marvels firmly, and inevitably you are filled with sorrow and yearning.’ With these words, the sparrow took flight and vanished into the air.» (Thaghari: 1973: 93)

6-5 .**Kulliyat-e Jame' al-Tamthil** (Habla Roudi)

The mentioned story appears in the sixteenth chapter of the book (under proverbs beginning with the letter T), serving as an allegory for the following verse.

Honor comes from contentment, and humiliation from greed	Live with your dignity, and do not see disgrace
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The story is about a nightingale perched on a tree, observes the children as they setting a trap. It mocks them and considers their efforts pointless. However, in the end, divine destiny causes the bird to fall into a trap, and it is later bought by someone. In this section, only the part of the narrative relevant to this research is presented.

«...Though the bird spoke many words to gain its freedom, it had no effect, and the child placed it in a cage and took it to the market. A man bought it and took it home. The bird spoke to the man, saying, ‘O man,

release me, for I have young ones to feed, and I fell into the trap for their sustenance. What benefit is there in keeping me? If you grant me freedom, I will give you three pieces of advice that will benefit you.’ The man said, ‘What are they? Speak, and I will set you free.’ The bird said, ‘I will give the first piece of advice in the cage, the second on your hand, and the third after being released.’ The man accepted. He said, ‘Take me to that same garden so I can speak.’ The man brought him to the garden and said, ‘Now, speak.’ The bird said, ‘If, by the decree of fate, something is lost, do not grieve or be saddened by it, for it is of no use, and do not burden your heart with unnecessary sorrow.’ The man said, ‘Well spoken. Now tell me the second piece of advice.’ The bird said, ‘Take me out of the cage so I can speak.’ The man said, ‘You want to escape and deceive me? After you fly away, how will I catch you again?’ The bird said, ‘A man’s word is one. Hold both my feet firmly so I can give you the second piece of advice.’ Then the man took him out of the cage. The bird said, ‘The second piece of advice is that if you hear an impossible story from someone, do not believe it, and do not be hopeful of an impossible promise.’ He said, ‘Tell me the third piece of advice.’ The bird said, ‘Release me so I can speak.’ So he released him. The bird flew to the top of a tree and praised God and said, ‘O generous man, the third piece of advice is that never let foolish greed make you appear contemptible and humbled before your fellow humans, and you will suffer misfortune because of its wickedness.

Just as I, because of the wickedness of greed, was ensnared. However, O young man, you showed me kindness. I will tell you something.’ The man said, ‘Speak.’ He said, ‘You were a very foolish man to have released me.’ He asked, ‘Why?’ The bird said, ‘Because in my stomach, there is a gem weighing 20 mithqals, and you have lost it.’ When the man heard this, his heart raced, and he struck his head, saying, ‘What a deception I have suffered, and I have lost a treasure so easily!’ The bird said, ‘O man, I have now given you three pieces of advice, and you have forgotten all three immediately. I advised you not to grieve over anything you lose, for it is useless. I have escaped from your hand, and even if you shout a thousand times, I will not come back to you. I was in your captivity, why did you trust my words and release me so that you now grieve, when your regret is of no use?

“The bird that has escaped from the trap	How can it willingly return to a snare?”
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“Don’t be deceived by my words now, don’t be tempted by false promises. Don’t think it’s possible, and don’t expect something that can’t be. My body weighs 20 mithqal; how can a 20 mithqal treasure fit inside it? Use your reason. Then, lament.”

Do not be held captive by greed, and consider the outcome	I told you not to believe an impossible thing
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“The man, embarrassed by the bird’ of paradise, said, ‘You speak the truth.’ The bird replied, ‘You have shown me kindness and generosity; The reward for that is also kindness. I brought you to this tree for this very reason, give blessing upon you to bestow a blessing.

At times, I will elevate you to the highest heights	At times, I will not allow you to see beneath your own feet.
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“The bird said, “You speak the truth, but when fate comes and greed comes into motion, a person becomes blind. This world is a place of causes and effects, and God, the ultimate cause of all causes, makes everything a cause for something else, so that through those means, the predestined provision of each person reaches them.” The translation maintains the original meaning and structure of the text. Here are some minor changes and clarifications:

To the foolish, He delivers sustenance,	That a hundred wise ones are left in awe
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Therefore, O believer, this parable is meant for you to understand that after every hardship, the Almighty has placed ease. The contraction and expansion of time are in the grasp of His power, as He has said: “And Allah gives provision, and restricts [it], and to Him you will return.” God does what He wills, and the portion of each person reaches him. Therefore, greed and avarice are useless, and cause a person’s humiliation. As has been said,

“Humiliation comes from greed,” and in the Hadith it is stated, “Beware of greed, for it is the present poverty.” Thus, it is necessary to avoid this evil trait and abstain from gatherings of people in whose nature there are signs of this deplorable characteristic, so that it may be a cause of prosperity in both worlds.» (Habla Roudi: 1992:282-284)

7. Comparison of Persian Prose Sources:

- Based on what has been discussed, the narrative has two characters: one human and one animal. These are referred to as the hunter and the bird. However, the different titles used in the Persian sources will be presented in the table below.

Characters	Javameal-Hikayat	Kimiaye Sa'adat	Tutinama	Jame' al-Tamthil
Hunter	Aman	A man	Aman	Child
Bird	Asparrow/ Little bird	Dunnock	Sparrow/ Dunnock	Nightingale

- The sources "Javame' al-Hekayat", "Tuti-Nameh", and "Jame' al-Tamthil" all mention the location of the event which is a «market». “A man had put a sparrow in a cage and brought it to the market to sell” (Aufi, 1984: 363). "A man bought a colorful, delicate sparrow in the Damascus market for a dirham from a hunter"(Al-Thaghri:1973:93)." A child placed it in a cage and brought it to the market” (Habla Roudi, 1992: 282).

Thus, the bird is purchased, whereas in "Kimiaya Sa'adat", the bird is captured.

- Apparently, "Javame al-Hikayat" and "Jame' al-Tamthil" share more similarities, as both reference the story of the "pot under the tree," which is interpreted as Divine Destiny. The concept of the golden pot is also discussed in the table below. On the other hand, Kimiaye Sa'adat and Tuti Nameh only mention the first and second pieces of advice, which are common to all the sources.

Javameal-Hikayat	Now there is a golden umbrella under this tree; take it and use it for your own purposes. The man dug in that place and found a gold coin. He said to him: "Is it strange that you saw a gold coin under the ground and you do not see a trap under the soil?" He said: "You do not know that when the Creator will bring a decree to pass, He will blind the seeing through the will of the ignorant so that they cannot see the way out." The man was satisfied with that benefit and became rich from that treasure and went home.
Jame'al-Tamthil	Raw greed will always make you despicable and humiliated among your peers, and you will be caught in calamity due to its ill omen.

- Similar to the Arabic sources, the bird offers the following pieces of advice: “Do not grieve over what is lost.”, “Do not believe in what is impossible.” In all sources, after giving these two pieces of advice and securing its freedom, the bird mentions the “pearl inside its stomach.”

- The locations where the bird suggests delivering its advice to the hunter, in sequential order, are as follows:

Javameal-Hikayat/ Jame'al—Tamthil	Cage-Hand-Tree
Kimiaye Sa'adat	Hand-Tree-Mountain
Tutinama	Hand-Hand-Tree

Another notable point is that in "Javame' al-Hikayat", before anything else, the bird and the hunter go to the desert. Meanwhile, in Jame'al-Tamthil, the bird asks the hunter to take it back to the same garden where it was previously.

- In "Kimiaye Sa'adat", the hunter's goal in capturing the bird is to slaughter and eat it: "The bird asked, Whatdo you want from me? The hunter replied, I will kill and eat you" (Ghazali Tousi, 2001: 162). In "Tuti Nameh", however, the man's purpose for buying the bird is to entertain his children: "He tied a string to its leg, held it in his hand, and took it home for his children to play with." (Al-Thughri: 1973:93).

• Upon hearing the bird's statement about the pearl inside its stomach, the hunter expresses regret and disappointment. In "Javame' al-Hikayat" does not mention this reaction, other sources describe it as follows: "The man bit his finger and said, 'Alas, what a pity!" (Ghazali Tousi, 2001: 162). "The man was immediately filled with regret and began wringing his hands." (Al-Thughri:1973:93). "Upon hearing this, the man's heart began to beat fast, and he struck his head, exclaiming, exclaiming how he had been so easily deceived and lost the treasure". (Habla Rudi, 1992: 282-284).

• Similar to the Arabic sources, the bird refutes the claim about the pearl by referencing its own weight. The specific expressions used in different sources are as follows:

Javami ul-Hikayat	"May all my members and parts not be worth ten mithqals
Kimiaye Sa'adat	All my flesh and wings were not worth even two mithqals".
Tuti-Nameh	For I am a weak bird. Where could a pearl of twenty mithqals fit in my crop"?
Jame'al-Tamthil	My body isn't even twenty mithqals, so how could a pearl of twenty mithqals fit in my stomach? It's an impossible thing".

- The bird refers to the valuable treasure inside its stomach using different terms in various sources: “Gowhar” (jewel) in "Javame' al-Hikayat" and "Jame' al-Tamthil". “Two pearls” in "Kimiaye-ye Sa'adat". • “Durr” (pearl) in "Tuti Nameh". In all cases, the weight of the treasure is stated to be 20 mithqals.

8. Comparison of Arabic and Persian Prose Sources:

- The subject and purpose of all the Arabic and Persian narratives are completely identical, which is: human greed that prevents them from understanding the truth.

- The structure and appearance of all the Arabic and Persian narratives are similar, but the Persian source "Kimiaye Sa'adat" is more similar to the Arabic sources. Below, we will briefly mention the similarities and differences between the two Arabic and Persian literatures.

- In Arabic literature, the sources "Hilyat al-Awliya", "Ihya' Ulum al-Din", "Al-Adhkiya", and "Al-'Iqd al-Farid", and in Persian literature, the source "Kimiaye Sa'adat" narrate the story from the perspective of a person named "Shaabi."

- In the source "Kamal al-Din", the bird is referred to as "Eusfur" (sparrow) while in the Persian sources "Javame' al-Hikayat" and "Tuti-Nameh" the equivalent term used is "gonjeshk" (sparrow).

- The initial dialogue between the bird and the hunter in the Arabic sources "Hilyat al-Awliya", "Ihya' Ulum al-Din", "Al-Adhkiya", and "Al-'Iqd al-Farid", and the Persian source "Kimiaye Sa'adat," are similar. For example: "A man caught a bird, and when it was in his hand, it said: "What do you want to do with me?" He replied: "I will slaughter you and eat you". It said, "I will not relieve your hunger nor satisfy your appetite, but I will teach you three things that are better for you than eating me." (Al-Isfahani, 1996: 316). "A man caught a sparrow. He said: "What do you want from me?" The bird replied: "Will you kill me and eat me?" He said: "I will kill you and eat you." The bird said: "Nothing will come from eating me, but I will teach you three things that are better than eating me." (Ghazali Tousi; 2001: 162).

- Only the Arabic source "Kamal al-Din" and the Persian source "Jame' al-Tamthil" refer to the third piece of advice, with the difference that the Persian source "Jame' al-Tamthil" also mentions the matter of a golden water pitcher after the third piece of advice (similar to the source "Javame' al-Hikayat"), while the rest of the Arabic and Persian prose sources mention only two pieces of advice.

- The places where the bird offers advice to the hunter in all the Arabic and Persian sources are "hand," "tree," and "mountain," as explained earlier.

- The weight of the pearl that the bird refers to is twenty mithqals in all the sources, except for the source "Kamal al-Din", where the bird refers to a pearl that weighs the same as a duck egg, described as "a pearl the size of a goose egg."

- The Arabic sources "Hilyat al-Awliya", "Ihya' Ulum al-Din", and "Al-Adhkiya" and the Persian source "Kimiaye Sa'adat", refer to "duratayn" (two pearls), while the sources "Al-'Iqd al-Farid", "Kamal al-Din", and "Tuti-Nameh" refer to "a dur" (one pearl).

- The sources "Kamal al-Din", "Javame' al-Hikayat", and "Jame' al-Tamthil" present three pieces of advice and conclude with a moral lesson.

- The sources "Ihya' Ulum al-Din" and "Kimiayi Sa'adat" refer to two pieces of advice, with the narrator providing a moral lesson at the end.

- After the second piece of advice in sources "Al-'Iqd al-Farid", "Hilyat al-Awliya", and "Al-Adhkiya", the bird mentioning its weight, denying its earlier words, and then flying away.

9. Persian Verse Sources:

9-1 Ilahi-Nameh (Attar)

The Ilahi-Nameh is a masnavi (narrative poem) by Sheikh Farid al-Din Attar of Neyshabouri, focused on mystical journey and spiritual teachings. It is composed in one volume and consists of twenty-two chapters. The referenced story appears in the thirteenth chapter under

the title "The Tale of Shaabi and the Man Who Caught a bird."

1	Sha'bi, the wise man, once told a tale	A man caught a bird on his trail
2	The bird spoke, "O man, what do you want from me?	And what do you want from this leg, head, and neck?
3	If you set me free	I will teach you three beneficial lessons
4	The first I'll share while in your hand	The second when I am safe on a branch
5	The third when I perch upon the mountain high	Where cliffs meet the endless sky
6	The man said, Tell me the first secret	Sawah spoke
7	That whatever is lost, if life remains	Don't grieve over it at any time
8	Upon these words, the man released the bird, as it had promised	and in that moment, the bird perched upon a branch
9	Then it shared the second piece of advice. If you hear something impossible	Do not believe it unless you see it with your own eyes
10	The bird spoke and flew away Until it reached a mountain's peak that day	From above, it called to the man below: "Oh, wretched one, lost in sorrow and woe"!
11	Inside me were two powerful pearls	Each weighing twenty mithqals
12	If you had killed me the	But losing me would have

	pearls would be yours	been a great mistake
13	The man's heart burned with envy and regret	he bits his finger in astonishment
14	He said to the bird, "Then what is the third word	Tell me why my sea of regret has grown and so deep
15	The bird replied, "You have no wisdom at all	That you have already forgotten the first two words
16	When you didn't accept even one of them	Why do you seek the third
17	I told you not to grieve over the past	And not to believe in the impossible, O pure-hearted one
18	You mourned too much for what was lost	And when I spoke of the impossible, you believed it
19	There are no pearls inside of me	not forty mithgals
20	Nor do I carry those glowing gems within me How could such a treasure exist in my body	Now you see me as a mad creature
21	Saying this, the bird flew from the mountain top	Leaving the man in sorrow and regret.
22	Whoever clings to impossibilities	Will spend his days and nights in bewilderment
23	You cannot step wherever you wish	Follow the command and observe wisely

24	Whoever walks without God's command	Burns like a candle, consumed from the top down
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(Attar:2009:278-279)

9-2 .Masnavi-ye Ma'navi (Balkhi)

The referenced tale is found in the fourth book of Masnavi-ye Ma'navi under the title:"The Story of the Captured Bird that advised: Do Not Regret the Past, Focus on the Present, and Do Not Waste Time in Remorse."

1	One bird was caught in a trap and snare	The bird spoke to him, O noble master
2	You have consumed so many oxen and wine	and sacrificed so many camels in sacrifice
3	You have not seen that time (of reckoning)	nor have you considered the parts of me
4	How long until I will give you three teachings	so that you may know whether I am beneath you or foolish
5	The first of these teachings is even in your hand	and the second is tied up with the knot of (your own) ignorance
6	And the third teaching I give you on the tree	that through these three teachings, you may

		become fortunate.
7	What is on your hand is indeed the word	do not believe in the impossible from anyone
8	When he spoke the first heavy teaching	he was freed and went to that wall
9	He said, "Do not grieve for what is past	for it has passed from you, so do not carry that regret
10	After that, he said to him, "In my body, we are bound	there are ten in stone, and one is orphaned
11	What is your wealth, what is the luck of your children	This gem by the truth of your life was
12	You passed away when you were still in the prime	and there should not be such a thing in existence again
13	Just as a pregnant woman would moan	the master was in turmoil, in a whirlwind
14	The bird said to him, "I did not teach you wisdom	so that you would not be grieved by past times
15	Since you have passed and gone, you are grieving	either you did not understand my teaching, or you are stubborn

16	And the second advice I gave you, from misguidance	Never believe any impossible words.
17	I am not merely three dirhams in weight, O lion	So how could I have ten dirhams within me?
18	The master returned to his sense and said, "Now	Tell me again that good, third piece of advice."
19	He said, "Yes, you have acted well, know this,	So that I may tell you the third piece of advice, freely given
20	Giving advice to a sleeping ignorant one	s like sowing seeds in barren soil.
21	The tear of stupidity and ignorance will not accept repair,	Give little seed of wisdom, O advisor

(Balkhi: 2014:837)

10. Analysis of Persian Poetic Sources:

- Rumi and Attar, drawing inspiration from ancient sources, expanded upon the tale and rendered it into verse while maintaining the same core message and theme.

- The titles “Sha’bi and Sa’weh” in Ilahi-Name by Attar and “A Man and the Bird” in Masnavi by Rumi are the characters in these poetic narratives.

- Similar to prose sources, the bird suggests a place to the man for delivering its advice. In Attar's version, these locations are "hand - a safe branch - a place on the mountain edge" while in Rumi's version, they are "hand - a mud-roof - a tree"
- The advice given by the bird is as follows:

Version	Admonition1	Admonition2
Ilahi-Nameh	No regret for what is lost	No belief in the impossible
"Masnavi-ye Ma'navi"	No belief in the impossible	No grieving over the past

- The bird then tests the man by mentioning a false pearl inside its stomach, which is described as "weighing twenty mithqals" in Attar's version and "ten dirhams" in Rumi's version.
- In the end, the bird denies its own claim and reveals the truth by referring to its actual weight: "My flesh does not even weigh two mithqals today." (Attar, 2009: 279) "I myself do not weigh even three dirhams, O Asad". (Rumi,2014: 838)
- In Attar’s version, the narrator concludes the story from their own perspective.
- Based on what has been said, Attar’s version is closer to the older sources of the story.

11. Story Elements:

11-1 Theme:

The allegorical fable of "The Hunter and the Bird" carries a moral and social theme, which revolves around human greed. All narrative elements work together to reinforce this theme, but what directly confronts the reader with the story's central idea are the three pieces of advice given by the bird, which ultimately lead to the story's moral conclusion. As Ghazali mentions in "Ihya Ulum": "This is an example of excessive human greed, which blinds one from perceiving the truth, leading them to believe that the impossible could happen" (Al-Ghazali, 2005: 1144). As observed in all versions of the story, the narrator (whether a writer, poet) employs animal allegory (fable) to convey the dominant idea within the narrative.

The core story in the narrative of Baluhar and Budasaf and is about the ignorance of the people. when greed and self-interest are involved, no advice is accepted, and matters are not judged according to reason. (Zarin-Koub; 1988:183)

11-2 .Plot

The plot of the story follows a logical sequence based on cause-and-effect relationships. As Mirsa adeghistates "The plot rationally and logically organizes the interdependence between events in the story. this sequence of events is connected through cause-and-effect

relationships and is structured with a coherent and reasoned pattern." (Mirsadeghi, 2015: 84).

At the beginning, the hunter captures the bird (cause), and since the bird has no escape route, the bird engages in conversation and asks the hunter about its fate (effect). The hunter responds that he intends to slaughter and eat the bird (cause), prompting the bird to offer an alternative proposal that would benefit the hunter instead (effect). As they agree on certain conditions, the bird gives its first piece of advice (cause), leading the hunter to release it (effect). After delivering the second piece of advice, the bird mentions the pearl inside its stomach (cause), which triggers the hunter's regret and sorrow (effect).

Then, the hunter requests a third piece of advice (cause), bringing the story closer to resolution. At this point, the bird reproaches the hunter for failing to follow the first two pieces of advice and reveals the truth-that the pearl never existed-before flying away (effect).

This chain of cause-and-effect relationships, like links in a chain, shapes the story's plot. The inciting incident occurs when the bird speaks for the first time and the hunter responds, leading to the bird's proposal and creating tension. Will the bird escape, or will the hunter accept the deal, or will he refuse? When the hunter accepts the offer, the first two pieces of advice are given, advancing the story's tension.

Then, by lying about the pearl, the bird tests the hunter, creating an internal conflict in the hunter's mind. This emotional turmoil fuels the story's development, leading the hunter to feel regret and self-reproach (climax).

Finally, when the hunter asks for the third piece of advice, the bird resolves the tension by revealing the truth, thus resolving the conflict and bringing the story to its conclusion.

Plot	
Initial situation	The bird's capture by the hunter
Inciting incident	The initial conversation between the hunter and the bird about the hunter's decision regarding the bird
complication	The clever suggestion of the bird to the hunter to save itself, followed by the offering of two initial advice
Suspense	The bird's reference to the presence of a valuable pearl in its beak
Conflict	The hunter's regret and self-blame
Climax	The hunter's pursuit to hear the third advice while he has not acted on the first two pieces of advice
Resolution	The bird informs about the reality and points to human greed

The use of suspense not only develops the plot, but also keeps the reader in a state of uncertainty, eager to know what happens next. This uncertainty allows the reader to speculate about possible outcomes and endings, further engaging them in the story.

11-3 . Dialogue:

Although dialogue helps to expand the plot and adds dynamism and movement to the story, but in this tale, the two participants in the conversation do not speak equally. In other words, the bird dominates the majority of the narrative, while the reader recognizes the hunter mainly through his actions and expressions of emotions, such as regret and sorrow. The table below presents a sample dialogue between the hunter and the bird from the Arabic source "Al-Iqd al-Farid".

	Bird	Hunter
Inciting Incident	She said, what do you want to do with me?	I'll slaughter you and then eat you
Rising Action	By God, I won't satisfy a craving nor will I satisfy hunger, but I will teach you three qualities that are better for you than eating me. The first I will teach you while I am in your hand, the second when I am on this tree, and the third when I am on	So he said: Bring the first.

	the mountain	
Rising Action	Do not regret what has passed	Bring the second one
Rising Action	Do not believe in what is not (real)	-----
Conflict	So she said: Oh, wretch! If you were to slaughter me, you would extract from my craw a pearl weighing twenty mithqals	Bring the third one
Resolution	You've forgotten the two, so how can I teach you the third? Didn't I tell you not to grieve over what you've missed? You grieved over me when I escaped you, and I told you, 'Don't believe in what cannot be, that it will be!' But you believed! I, with my bones and feathers, don't weigh twenty mithqals, so how could there be in my crop what weighs "that much	

As observed in the table, in the dialogue between the hunter and the bird, although the hunter speaks less, his brief responses and requests, along with setting the

stage for the bird's speeches, help move the story forward. For example, at the beginning of the conversation, when the bird asks, "What will you do with me?", the hunter's answer, which serves as a warning for the bird, sets the story in motion and can be considered the inciting incident. Then, the bird quickly reacts to save its life and enters into negotiations.

Also, when the hunter does not follow the first two pieces of advice and asks for the third, this behavior gives the bird the opportunity to scold the hunter, awaken him from his negligence, and resolve the story's conflict.

As mentioned, the dialogue in this story takes the form of a question and answer, which breathes life into the narrative and makes it seem more realistic. It almost makes the audience envision the bird as a human character, forgetting that it is an animal in the story.

11-4. Character:

As mentioned, the story is a type of fable or allegorical tale. Therefore, the bird, referred to by various names (Lark-bird-Sparrow-Chicken), is the main character. The bird who occupies most of the story, speaks like a human and cleverly achieves finding a way to escape the hunter's trap. In addition to being a symbol of wisdom, the bird also takes on the role of a teacher, offering advice to the hunter and the audience. Through dialogue, the bird drives the story forward. It first catches the hunter's attention, convinces him not to kill it, and then shares two pieces of advice. Then, by

claiming to have a precious pearl in its stomach, it tests the hunter and reveals the hunter's greed.

When the bird sees that the hunter has ignored its advice, it scolds him, reveals the truth, and flies away. The bird represents wise individuals who seek to teach others through moral lessons. The hunter, the human character, is driven by greed and desire, leading him to regret his actions. He represents those who, despite receiving advice, remain ignorant and inattentive to wisdom, showing a lack of understanding.

The narrator describes the characters and their personalities indirectly, a technique consistently used across all versions of the story, allowing the audience to recognize the characters through their actions and words.

11-5 . Point of View

"Point of view or narrative perspective is the method through which the author presents the story's elements and materials to the reader, and it essentially reflects the relationship between the author and the narrative" (MirSadeghi; 2015: 505).

In this tale, the narrator is an all-knowing observer of all aspects and events of the story. Therefore, the point of view in all versions of the narrative is omniscient. The narrator recounts the dialogue between the characters through their language and fully describes them, demonstrating a complete understanding of their personalities.

11-6. Setting

In this tale, the time of events is not specified, and the narrator recounts it from others. The phrase “once upon a time” mentioned only in the source of "Kamal al-Din" which still does not refer to a specific time. The place where the bird and the human meet is described as a “garden” (bustan) in "Kamal al-Din", as “market, house, desert” in "Javame’ al-Hikayat", and as “Damascus market” in "Tuti-nameh." Regarding the place where the bird offers its advice to the hunter, it was mentioned earlier. Now, all the sources are presented together in the table below:

Arabic sources		Persian sources	
Al-Iqd al-Farid	Hand-tree-mountain	Javame al-Hikayat	Tree
Kamal al-Din	Hand-tree-mountain	KimiayeSa'adat	Hand-tree-mountain
Hilyat al-Awliya	Hand-tree-mountain	Tutinama	Hand-tree
Ihya’ Ulum al-Din	Hand-tree-mountain	Jame'al-Tamthil	-
Al-Adhkiya	Hand-tree-mountain	Ilahi-Nameh	Hand- safe branch-mountain ridge
Nathr al-Dur	-	Masnavi-ye Ma'navi	Hand-mud plastered-tree

12. Results:

The well-known tale of “The Talking Bird” revolves around a conversation between a bird and a hunter, during which the bird offers three pieces of advice to the audience: “not regretting the past,” “not believing false statements,” and “overcoming greed and desire.” The key findings of this study are as follows:

- “The Talking Bird” fable is a moralistic tale that appears in both Arabic and Persian prose literature. Renowned Persian poets have also reimagined the story in verse, incorporating narrative techniques and literary elements.

- The oldest known source of this tale in Arabic literature has been found in "Al-Iqd al-Farid" by Ibn Abd Rabbih.

- The characters in the story include a human (the hunter) and a bird. The bird, as the central character, is mentioned under various names, such as lark, bird, Sparrow, Bird, Parrot, Nightingale, and Chicken.

- Although the structure of the story varies across prose and verse sources, the theme remains the same: human greed blinds people from seeing the truth. Through the bird’s advice, the storyteller aims to influence the audience, urging them against not to regret over the past or believe in things that are not real.

- Among the Persian poetic versions, Attar's adaptation is closer to the original Arabic source.

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